

Family AI Safety Guide

Using AI Safely and Responsibly with Your Family

Introduction

Welcome to the Family AI Safety Guide! This guide will help you and your family use AI tools safely, responsibly, and effectively. Whether you're new to AI or already using it, these guidelines will ensure everyone stays protected.

The 3 Golden Rules

1. Protect Privacy

Never share personal information with AI systems.

2. Verify Everything

AI can make mistakes - always fact-check important information.

3. Think Critically

Use AI to enhance your thinking, not replace it.

What NOT to Share with AI

NEVER Share These:

Personal Identifiers:

- Full names combined with location
- Complete addresses (street, city, postcode)

- Phone numbers
- Email addresses (when paired with other info)
- Dates of birth
- Photos of faces

Sensitive Information:

- Passwords or PINs
- Bank account details
- Credit card numbers
- National Insurance / Social Security numbers
- Medical record numbers
- School or workplace IDs

Private Details:

- Medical conditions or diagnoses
- Mental health information
- Legal issues or court cases
- Financial problems or debt details
- Relationship conflicts with identifying details
- Children's full names, ages, and locations together

Safe Ways to Rewrite Prompts

✗ UNSAFE:

"My son Jake, 7, at Riverside Primary School in Manchester is struggling with reading comprehension."

✓ SAFE:

"My 7-year-old is struggling with reading comprehension. What strategies can help?"

✗ UNSAFE:

"I live at 42 Oak Street, Birmingham B12 3XY. What's the best internet provider?"

 **SAFE:**

"I'm in the West Midlands area. What internet providers have good service here?"

 **UNSAFE:**

"My email is sarah.jones@email.com and I need help writing a complaint about my phone contract."

 **SAFE:**

"Help me write a complaint letter about a phone contract. I've had poor service and want a refund."

Age-Appropriate AI Use

Ages 5-8: Supervised Only

- **Always** sit with them
- Use child-friendly AI tools
- Explain: "The computer tries to help but can make mistakes"
- Focus on: creative stories, simple questions, fun learning

Example Activities:

- "Tell me a story about a friendly dragon"
 - "What do elephants eat?"
 - "Help me think of rhymes for 'cat'"
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Ages 9-12: Supervised with Guidance

- Sit nearby and check frequently
- Review all AI responses together

- Teach them to spot incorrect information
- Focus on: homework help (not doing it for them), creativity, research

Teaching Moment: "Let's ask AI this question. Then let's look it up in a book or trusted website to check if it's right!"

Approved Uses:

- Explaining concepts they're learning
 - Brainstorming creative writing ideas
 - Practice spelling or math (but they do the work!)
 - Learning about topics they're curious about
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Ages 13-16: Monitored Independence

- Set clear rules and expectations
- Regular check-ins about AI use
- Teach critical thinking and fact-checking
- Focus on: research, studying, appropriate social interaction

Family Agreement Includes:

- What AI can and can't be used for
 - Privacy rules (their own and others')
 - No cheating on schoolwork
 - Come to parents with concerns
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Ages 16+: Responsible Use with Oversight

- Treat them as young adults
 - Open conversations about AI ethics
 - Guide on professional use (CVs, job applications)
 - Discuss misinformation and AI-generated content
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Homework and AI: The Right Way

WRONG WAY (Cheating):

"Write my essay about Shakespeare's Macbeth"

RIGHT WAY (Learning):

"Explain the main themes in Macbeth so I can understand them better for my essay"

The Learning Approach:

1. Understand First

- Use AI to explain concepts
- Ask "why" and "how" questions

2. Get Ideas

- Brainstorm topics or approaches
- Discuss different perspectives

3. Do Your Own Work

- Write your own essays/answers
- Show your own thinking

4. Check and Improve

- Ask AI to review for clarity (not do it for you)
 - Get suggestions for improvement
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Recognizing AI Hallucinations

AI "hallucinations" are when AI confidently states false information. Here's how to spot them:

Red Flags:

1. Overly Specific Claims

- "This happened on January 15, 2022 at 3:47 PM" (too precise without source)

2. Made-up Sources

- "According to Dr. Smith's 2023 study..." (source doesn't exist)

3. Impossible Events

- Dates that don't match (Shakespeare using computers)
- Events that couldn't have happened

4. Contradictions

- Says one thing, then contradicts itself
- Different answer to same question

How to Verify:

- Search reputable sources (BBC, NHS, .gov sites)
 - Check multiple sources
 - Ask: "Does this sound right?"
 - When in doubt, ask a human expert
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Scams and Deepfakes

AI-Generated Scams to Watch For:

Fake Emails/Messages:

- AI can write convincing phishing emails
- Check sender address carefully
- Look for requests for money or personal info

Voice Cloning:

- Scammers can clone voices from social media
- If "family member" calls asking for money, verify!
- Call them back on a known number
- Use a secret family code word

Deepfake Videos:

- AI can create fake videos of real people
- Check: lighting, lip sync, edges of face
- Verify through official channels
- Teach kids: "Seeing isn't always believing"

Family Safety Protocol:

1. Create a Code Word

- Only family knows it
- Use if calling about emergencies/money

2. Verify Emergency Calls

- Hang up
- Call back on known number
- Contact other family members

3. Never Rush

- Scammers create urgency
 - Take time to verify
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When NOT to Use AI

AI should NEVER replace professional advice for:



Medical Issues

- Symptoms or diagnosis
- Medication questions
- Mental health crises
- Emergency situations

Instead: See your GP, call 111, or 999 for emergencies

Legal Matters

- Legal advice or contracts
- Court issues
- Rights and responsibilities
- Official documents

Instead: Consult a solicitor or Citizens Advice

Financial Decisions

- Investment advice
- Debt management
- Benefits questions
- Tax issues

Instead: See a financial advisor or accountant

Emergencies

- Medical emergencies
- Safety threats
- Crime reporting
- Urgent help needed

Instead: Call 999 or appropriate emergency service

Family AI Agreement Template

Our Family's AI Rules:

We agree to:

☐ Only use AI for appropriate, helpful purposes ☐ Never share personal information ☐
Always fact-check important information ☐ Use AI to learn, not to avoid learning ☐ Ask

for help when unsure ☐ Respect others' privacy ☐ Not use AI to bully, harass, or deceive
☐ Credit AI when we use it (schoolwork, etc.)

If something goes wrong:

- We'll talk about it openly without fear
- We'll learn from mistakes together
- We'll update our rules as needed

Signed:

- Parent/Guardian: _____
- Children: _____

Date: _____

Review Date: _____ (every 6 months)

Red Flags for Parents

Watch for these warning signs:

- ▶ Child is secretive about AI use
- ▶ Sudden improvement in homework (possible cheating)
- ▶ Spending excessive time with AI chatbots
- ▶ Sharing personal information
- ▶ Using AI for inappropriate content
- ▶ Emotional attachment to AI assistant

What to do:

- Have a calm, non-judgmental conversation
 - Explain why you're concerned
 - Review and reinforce safety rules
 - Consider supervised use for a while
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Privacy Settings and Controls

On Devices:

- Use parental control apps

- Monitor browser history
- Set up screen time limits
- Create separate child accounts

With AI Tools:

- Review each platform's privacy policy
- Opt out of data collection when possible
- Use temporary/incognito browsing
- Delete conversation history regularly

At Home:

- AI devices in common areas (not bedrooms)
 - Regular "tech audits" together
 - Open door policy for questions
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Teaching Critical Thinking

Help your children question and think:

Ask These Questions:

- "How do you know that's true?"
- "What sources can we check?"
- "Does that make sense?"
- "What might AI have gotten wrong?"
- "Would a human expert agree?"

Teach Them to:

- Question everything
 - Seek multiple sources
 - Think for themselves
 - Ask "Why?" and "How?"
 - Trust their gut feelings
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Resources for Help

If You're Worried:

- **NSPCC:** 0808 800 5000
- **Childline:** 0800 1111 (for children)
- **Internet Matters:** internetmatters.org
- **UK Safer Internet Centre:** saferinternet.org.uk

Learn More:

- **The AI Ark:** theaiark.org
 - **Alongside AI Basics:** alongside-ai-basics.netlify.app
 - **Common Sense Media:** commonsensemedia.org
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Final Thoughts

AI is a powerful tool that can enhance learning, creativity, and daily life. With proper guidance and safety measures, your family can enjoy the benefits while staying protected.

Remember:

- Open communication is key
 - Mistakes are learning opportunities
 - Technology changes - keep learning together
 - You're doing great by reading this guide!
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For more resources visit: theaiark.org*